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Fast ODE-based Sampling for Diffusion Models in Around 5 Steps

Zhenyu Zhou Defang Chen† Can Wang Chun Chen
The State Key Laboratory of Blockchain and Data Security,
Zhejiang University, China
{zhyzhou, defchern, wcan, chenc}@zju.edu.cn

Abstract

Sampling from diffusion models can be treated as solving the corresponding ordinary differential equations (ODEs), with the aim of obtaining an accurate solution with as few number of function evaluations (NFE) as possible. Recently, various fast samplers utilizing higher-order ODE solvers have emerged and achieved better performance than the initial first-order one. However, these numerical methods inherently result in certain approximation errors, which significantly degrades sample quality with extremely small NFE (e.g., around 5). In contrast, based on the geometric observation that each sampling trajectory almost lies in a two-dimensional subspace embedded in the ambient space, we propose ***A****pproximate* ***ME****an-****D****irection Solver (AMED-Solver) that eliminates truncation errors by directly learning the mean direction for fast diffusion sampling. Besides, our method can be easily used as a plugin to further improve existing ODE-based samplers. Extensive experiments on image synthesis with the resolution ranging from 32 to 512 demonstrate the effectiveness of our method. With only 5 NFE, we achieve 6.61 FID on CIFAR-10, 10.74 FID on ImageNet 64×64, and 13.20 FID on LSUN Bedroom. Our code is available at* https://github.com/zju-pi/diff-sampler.

1. Introduction

Diffusion models have been attracting growing attentions in recent years due to their impressive generative capability [9, 34, 36, 38]. Given a noise input, they are able to generate a realistic output by performing iterative denoising steps with the score function [15, 42, 45]. This process can be interpreted as applying a certain numerical discretization on a stochastic differential equation (SDE), or more commonly, its corresponding probability flow ordinary differential equation (PF-ODE) [45]. Comparing to other generative models such as GANs [12] and VAEs [19], diffusion models have the advantages in high sample quality and stable training, but suffer from slow sampling speed, which poses a great challenge to their applications.

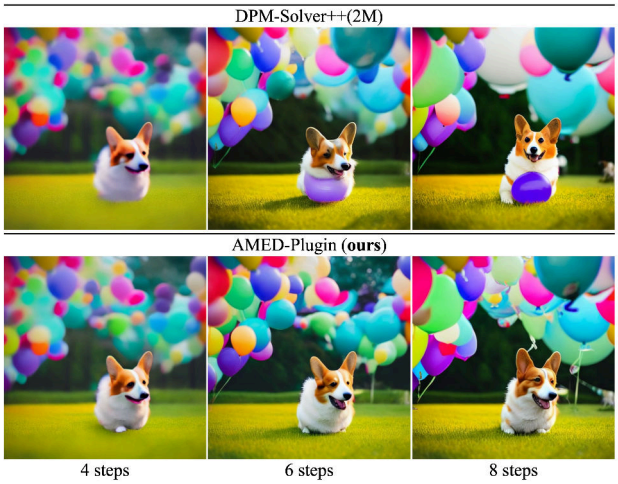
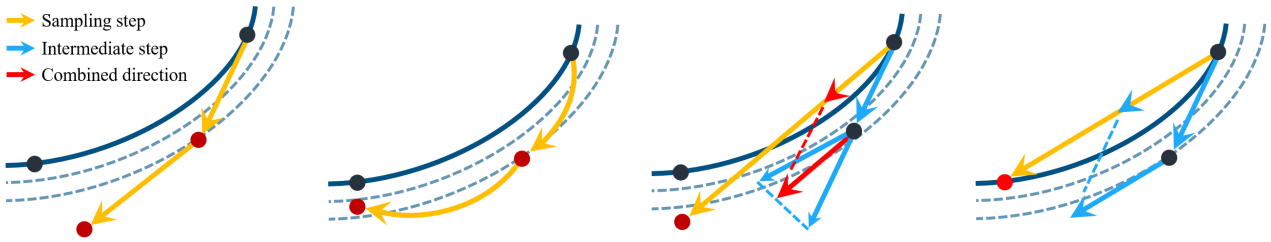


Figure 1. Synthesized images by Stable-Diffusion [34] with a default classifier-free guidance scale 7.5 and a text prompt "*A Corgi on the grass surrounded by a cluster of colorful balloons*". Our method improves DPM-Solver++(2M) [26] in sample quality.

Existing methods for accelerating diffusion sampling fall into two main streams. One is designing faster numerical solvers to increase step size while maintaining small truncation errors [10, 18, 23, 25, 43, 51]. They can be further categorized as *single-step* solvers and *multi-step* solvers [2]. The former computes the next step solution only using information from the current time step, while the latter uses multiple past time steps. These methods have successfully reduced the number of function evaluations (NFE) from 1000 to less than 20, almost without affecting the sample quality. Another kind of methods aim to build a one-to-one mapping between the data distribution and the pre-specified noise distribution [4, 24, 27, 39, 46], based on the idea of knowledge distillation. With a well-trained student model in hand, high-quality generation can be achieved with only one NFE. However, training such a student model either

†Corresponding author



(a) DDIM solver. (b) Multi-step solvers. (c) Generalized DPM-Solver-2. (d) AMED-Solver (ours).

Figure 2. Comparison of various ODE solvers. Red dots depict the actual sampling step of different solvers. (a) DDIM solver [43] applies Euler discretization on PF-ODEs. In every sampling step, it follows the gradient direction to give the solution for next time step. (b) Multi-step solvers [23, 26, 51, 52] require current gradient and several records of history gradients and then follow the combination of these gradients to give the solution. (c) In generalized DPM-Solver-2 [25], there is a hyper-parameter r controlling the location of intermediate time step. $r = 0.5$ recovers the default DPM-Solver-2 and $r = 1$ recovers Heun's second method [18]. The gradient for sampling step is given by the combination of gradients at intermediate and current time steps (see Tab. 1). (d) Our proposed AMED-Solver seeks to find the intermediate time step and the scaling factor that gives nearly optimal gradient directing to the ground truth solution. This gradient used for sampling step is adaptively learned instead of the heuristic assigned as DPM-Solver-2.

requires pre-generation of millions of images [24, 27], or huge training cost with carefully modified training procedure [4, 39, 46]. Besides, distillation-based models cannot guarantee the increase of sample quality given more NFE and they have difficulty in likelihood evaluation.

In this paper, we further boost ODE-based sampling for diffusion models in around 5 steps. Based on the geometric property that each sampling trajectory approximately lies in a two-dimensional subspace embedded in the high-dimension space, we propose ***A**pproximate **ME**an-**D**irection Solver* (AMED-Solver), a single-step ODE solver that learns to predict the mean direction in every sampling step. A comparison of various ODE solvers is illustrated in Fig. 2. We also extend our method to any ODE solvers as a plugin. When applying AMED-Plugin on the improved PNDM solver [51], we achieve FID of 6.61 on CIFAR-10, 10.74 on ImageNet 64×64, and 13.20 on LSUN Bedroom. Our main contributions are as follows:

- We introduce AMED-Solver, a new single-step ODE solver for diffusion models that eliminates truncation errors by design.
- We propose AMED-Plugin that can be applied to any ODE solvers with a small training overhead and a negligible sampling overhead.
- Extensive experiments on various datasets validate the effectiveness of our method in fast image generation.

2. Background

2.1. Diffusion Models

The forward diffusion process can be formalized as a SDE:

$$\mathrm{d}\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{f}(\mathbf{x}, t)\mathrm{d}t + g(t)\mathrm{d}\mathbf{w}_t, \tag{1}$$

where $\mathbf{f}(\cdot, t) : \mathbb{R}^d \to \mathbb{R}^d, g(\cdot) : \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{R}$ are drift and diffusion coefficients, respectively, and $\mathbf{w}_t \in \mathbb{R}^d$ is the standard Wiener process [31]. This forward process forms a continuous stochastic process $\{\mathbf{x}_t\}_{t=0}^T$ and the associated probability density $\{p_t(\mathbf{x})\}_{t=0}^T$, to make the sample $\mathbf{x}_0$ from the implicit data distribution $p_d = p_0$ approximately distribute as the pre-specified noise distribution, *i.e.*, $p_T \approx p_n$. Given an encoding $\mathbf{x}_T \sim p_n$, generation is then performed with the reversal of Eq. (1) [1, 11]. Remarkably, there exists a probability flow ODE (PF-ODE)

$$\mathrm{d}\mathbf{x} = \left[\mathbf{f}(\mathbf{x}, t) - \frac{1}{2}g(t)^2\nabla_{\mathbf{x}} \log p_t(\mathbf{x})\right]\mathrm{d}t, \tag{2}$$

sharing the same marginals with the reverse SDE [29, 45], and $\nabla_{\mathbf{x}} \log p_t(\mathbf{x})$ is known as the *score function* [16, 28]. Generally, this PF-ODE is preferred in practice for its conceptual simplicity, sampling efficiency and unique encoding [45]. Throughout this paper, we follow the configuration of EDM [18] by setting $\mathbf{f}(\mathbf{x}, t) = \mathbf{0}$, $g(t) = \sqrt{2t}$ and $\sigma(t) = t$. In this case, the reciprocal of t^2 equals to the *signal-to-noise ratio* [20] and the perturbation kernel is

$$p_t(\mathbf{x}|\mathbf{x}_0) = \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{x}; \mathbf{x}_0, t^2\mathbf{I}). \tag{3}$$

To simulate the PF-ODE, we usually train a U-Net [15, 35] predicting $\mathbf{s}_\theta(\mathbf{x}, t)$ to approximate the intractable $\nabla_{\mathbf{x}} \log p_t(\mathbf{x})$. There are mainly two parameterizations in the literature. One uses a noise prediction model $\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_\theta(\mathbf{x}, t)$ predicting the Gaussian noise added to $\mathbf{x}$ at time t [15, 43], and another uses a data prediction model $\mathbf{D}_\theta(\mathbf{x}, t)$ predicting the denoising output of $\mathbf{x}$ from time t to 0 [6, 18, 26]. They have the following relationship in our setting:

$$\mathbf{s}_\theta(\mathbf{x}, t) = -\frac{\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_\theta(\mathbf{x}, t)}{t} = \frac{\mathbf{D}_\theta(\mathbf{x}, t) - \mathbf{x}}{t^2}. \tag{4}$$

The training of diffusion models in the noise prediction notation is performed by minimizing a weighted combination of the least squares estimations:

$$\mathbb{E}_{\mathbf{x}\sim p_d,\boldsymbol{\epsilon}\sim\mathcal{N}(\mathbf{0},\mathbf{I})}\|\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_{\boldsymbol{\theta}}(\mathbf{x}+t\boldsymbol{\epsilon};t)-\boldsymbol{\epsilon}\|_2^2. \tag{5}$$

We then plug the learned score function Eq. (4) into Eq. (2) to obtain a simple formulation for the PF-ODE

$$\mathrm{d}\mathbf{x}=\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_\theta(\mathbf{x},t)\mathrm{d}t. \tag{6}$$

The *sampling trajectory* $\{\mathbf{x}_{t_n}\}_{n=1}^N$ is obtained by first draw $\mathbf{x}_{t_N}\sim p_n=\mathcal{N}(\mathbf{0},T^2\mathbf{I})$ and then solve Eq. (6) with $N-1$ steps following time schedule $\Gamma=\{t_1=\epsilon,\cdots,t_N=T\}$.

2.2. Categorization of Previous Fast ODE Solvers

To accelerate diffusion sampling, various fast ODE solvers have been proposed, which can be classified into *single-step solvers* or *multi-step solvers* [2]. Single-step solvers including DDIM [43], EDM [18] and DPM-Solver [25] which only use the information from the current time step to compute the solution for the next time step, while multi-step solvers including PNDM [23] and DEIS [51] utilize multiple past time steps to compute the next time step (see Fig. 2 for an intuitive comparison). We emphasize that one should differ single-step ODE solvers from single-step (NFE=1) distillation-based methods [27, 39, 46].

The advantages of single-step methods lie in the easy implementation and the ability to self-start since no history record is required. However, as illustrated in Fig. 3, they suffer from fast degradation of sample quality especially when the NFE budget is limited. The reason may be that the actual sampling steps of multi-step solvers are twice as much as those of single-step solvers with the same NFE, enabling them to adjust directions more frequently and flexibly. We will show that our proposed AMED-Solver can largely fix this issue with learned mean directions.

3. Our Proposed AMED-Solver

In this section, we propose AMED-Solver, a single-step ODE solver for diffusion models that releases the potential of single-step solvers in extremely small NFE, enabling them to match or even surpass the performance of multi-step solvers. Furthermore, our proposed method can be generalized as a plugin on any ODE solver, yielding promising improvement across various datasets. Our key observation is that the sampling trajectory generated by Eq. (6) nearly lies in a two-dimensional subspace embedded in high-dimensional space, which motivates us to minimize the discretization error with the mean value theorem.

3.1. The Sampling Trajectory Almost Lies in a Two-Dimensional Subspace

The sampling trajectory generated by solving Eq. (6) exhibits an extremely simple geometric structure and has an implicit connection to annealed mean shift, as revealed in the previous work [6]. Each sample starting from the noise distribution approaches the data manifold along a smooth, quasi-linear sampling trajectory in a monotone likelihood increasing way. Besides, all trajectories from different initial points share the similar geometric shape, whether in the conditional or unconditional generation case [6].

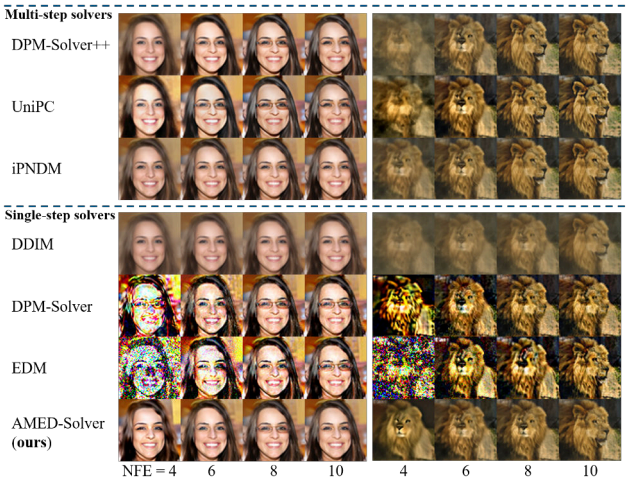


Figure 3. The sample quality degradation of multi-step and single-step ODE solvers. The quality of images generated by single-step solvers, especially higher-order ones including DPM-Solver-2 [25] and EDM [18], rapidly decreases as NFE decreases, while our proposed AMED-Solver largely mitigates such degradation. Examples are from FFHQ 64×64 [17] and ImageNet 64×64 [37].

In this paper, we further point out that the sampling trajectory generated by ODE solvers almost lies in a two-dimensional plane embedded in a high-dimensional space. We experimentally validate this claim by performing Principal Component Analysis (PCA) for 1k sampling trajectories on different datasets including CIFAR10 32×32 [21], FFHQ 64×64 [17], ImageNet 64×64 [37] and LSUN Bedroom 256×256 [50]. As illustrated in Fig. 4, the relative projection error using two principal components is no more than 8% and always stays in a small level. Besides, the sample variance can be fully explained using only two principal components. Given the vast image space with dimensions of 3072 (3×32×32), 12288 (3×64×64), or 196608 (3×256×256), the sampling trajectories show intriguing property that their dynamics can almost be described using only two principal components.

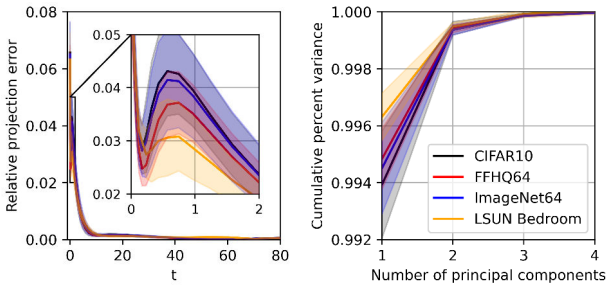
3.2. Approximate Mean-Direction Solver

With the geometric intuition, we next explain our methods in more detail. The exact solution of Eq. (6) is:

$$\mathbf{x}_{t_n}=\mathbf{x}_{t_{n+1}}+\int_{t_{n+1}}^{t_n}\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_\theta(\mathbf{x}_t,t)\mathrm{d}t. \tag{7}$$

Method	Gradient term	Source of s_n	Source of c_n
DDIM [43]	$c_n\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_\theta(\mathbf{x}_{t_{n+1}}, t_{n+1})$	-	1
EDM [18]	$c_n\left(\frac{1}{2}\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_\theta(\mathbf{x}_{s_n}, s_n) + \frac{1}{2}\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_\theta(\mathbf{x}_{t_{n+1}}, t_{n+1})\right)$	t_n	1
Generalized DPM-Solver-2 [25]	$c_n\left(\frac{1}{2r}\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_\theta(\mathbf{x}_{s_n}, s_n) + (1-\frac{1}{2r})\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_\theta(\mathbf{x}_{t_{n+1}}, t_{n+1})\right)$	$t_n^r t_{n+1}^{1-r}$, $r \in (0, 1]$	1
AMED-Solver (ours)	$c_n\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_\theta(\mathbf{x}_{s_n}, s_n)$	Learned	Learned

Table 1. Comparison of various single-step ODE solvers.



(a) Relative deviation. (b) Variance explained by top PCs.

Figure 4. We perform PCA to each sampling trajectory $\{\mathbf{x}_t\}_{t=\epsilon}^T$. (a) These trajectories are projected into a 2D subspace spanned by the top 2 principal components to get $\{\tilde{\mathbf{x}}_t\}_{t=\epsilon}^T$ and the relative projection error is calculated as $\|\mathbf{x}_t - \tilde{\mathbf{x}}_t\|_2 \,/\, \|\mathbf{x}_t\|_2$. (b) We progressively increase the number of principal components and calculate the cumulative percent variance as $\mathrm{Var}(\{\tilde{\mathbf{x}}_t\}_{t=\epsilon}^T)/\mathrm{Var}(\{\mathbf{x}_t\}_{t=\epsilon}^T)$. The results are obtained by averaging 1k sampling trajectories using EDM solver [18] with 80 NFE.

Various numerical approximations to the integral above correspond to different types of fast ODE-based solvers. For instance, direct explicit rectangle method gives DDIM [43], linear multi-step method yields PNDM [23], Taylor expansion yields DPM-Solver [25] and polynomial extrapolation recovers DEIS [51]. Different from these works, we derive our method more directly by expecting that the *mean value theorem* holds for the integral involved so that we can find an intermediate time step $s_n \in (t_n, t_{n+1})$ and a scaling factor $c_n \in \mathbb{R}$ that satisfy

$$\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_\theta(\mathbf{x}_{s_n}, s_n) = \frac{1}{c_n(t_n - t_{n+1})}\int_{t_{n+1}}^{t_n} \boldsymbol{\epsilon}_\theta(\mathbf{x}_t, t)\mathrm{d}t \tag{8}$$

Although the well-known mean value theorem for real-valued functions does not hold in vector-valued case [7], the remarkable geometric property that the sampling trajectory $\{\mathbf{x}_t\}_{t=\epsilon}^T$ almost lies in a two-dimensional subspace guarantees our use. By properly choosing s_n and c_n, we are able to achieve an approximation of Eq. (7) by

$$\mathbf{x}_{t_n} \approx \mathbf{x}_{t_{n+1}} + c_n(t_n - t_{n+1})\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_\theta(\mathbf{x}_{s_n}, s_n). \tag{9}$$

This formulation gives a single-step ODE solver. The DPM-Solver-2 [25] can be recovered by setting $s_n = \sqrt{t_n t_{n+1}}$ and $c_n = 1$. In Tab. 1, we compare various single-step solvers by generalizing $c_n\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_\theta(\mathbf{x}_{s_n}, s_n)$ as the *gradient term*.

For the choose of $\{s_n\}_{n=1}^{N-1}$ and $\{c_n\}_{n=1}^{N-1}$, we train a shallow neural network g_ϕ (named as *AMED predictor*) based on distillation with small training and negligible sampling costs. Briefly, given samples $\mathbf{y}_{t_n}, \mathbf{y}_{t_{n+1}}$ on the teacher sampling trajectory and $\mathbf{x}_{t_{n+1}}$ on the student sampling trajectory, g_ϕ gives s_n and c_n that minimizes $d\left(\mathbf{x}_{t_n}, \mathbf{y}_{t_n}\right)$ where $\mathbf{x}_{t_n}$ is given by Eq. (9) and $d(\cdot,\cdot)$ is a distance metric. Since we seek to find a mean-direction that best approximates the integral in Eq. (8), we name our proposed single-step ODE solver Eq. (9) as ***A**pproximate **ME**an-**D**irection Solver*, dubbed as AMED-Solver. Before specifying the training and sampling details, we proceed to generalize our idea as a plugin to the existing fast ODE solvers.

3.3. AMED as A Plugin

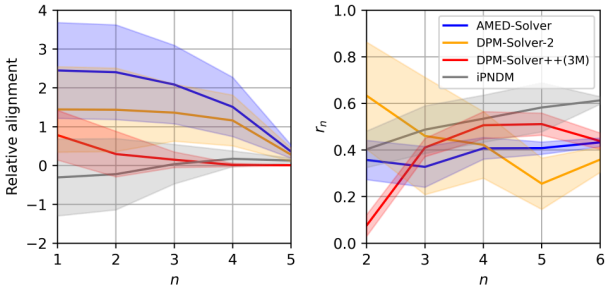
The idea of AMED can be used to further improve existing fast ODE solvers for diffusion models. Throughout our analysis, we take the polynomial schedule [18] as example:

$$t_n = (t_1^{1/\rho} + \frac{n-1}{N-1}(t_N^{1/\rho} - t_1^{1/\rho}))^\rho. \tag{10}$$

Note that another usually used uniform logSNR schedule is actually the limit of Eq. (10) as ρ approaches $+\infty$.

Given a time schedule $\Gamma = \{t_1 = \epsilon, \cdots, t_N = T\}$, the AMED-Solver is obtained by performing extra model evaluations at $s_n \in (t_n, t_{n+1}), n = 1, \cdots, N-1$. Under the same manner, we are able to improve any ODE solvers by predicting $\{s_n\}_{n=1}^{N-1}$ and $\{c_n\}_{n=1}^{N-1}$ that best aligns the student and teacher sampling trajectories.

We validate this by an experiment where we fix $c_n = 1$ and first generate a ground truth trajectory $\{\mathbf{x}_{t_n}^G\}_{n=1}^N$ using Heun's second method with 80 NFE and extract samples at Γ. For every ODE solver, we generate a baseline trajectory $\{\mathbf{x}_{t_n}^B\}_{n=1}^N$ by performing evaluations at $s_n = \sqrt{t_n t_{n+1}}$ as DPM-Solver-2 [25] does. We then apply a grid search on r_n, giving $s_n = t_n^{r_n} t_{n+1}^{1-r_n}$ and a searched trajectory $\{\mathbf{x}_{t_n}^S\}_{n=1}^N$. We define the relative alignment to be $\left\|\mathbf{x}_{t_n}^B - \mathbf{x}_{t_n}^G\right\|_2 - \left\|\mathbf{x}_{t_n}^S - \mathbf{x}_{t_n}^G\right\|_2$. Positive relative alignment value indicates that the searched trajectory $\{\mathbf{x}_{t_n}^S\}_{n=1}^N$ is closer to the ground truth trajectory $\{\mathbf{x}_{t_n}^G\}_{n=1}^N$ than the baseline trajectory $\{\mathbf{x}_{t_n}^B\}_{n=1}^N$. As shown in Fig. 5, the relative alignment value keeps positive in most cases, meaning



(a) Relative alignment at time t_n. (b) Best r_n given by grid search.

Figure 5. Effectiveness of searching the intermediate time steps. Given a time schedule $\Gamma = \{t_1 = \epsilon, \cdots, t_N = T\}$ where $\epsilon = 0.002, T = 80, N = 6$, we first generate a ground truth trajectory. For each ODE solver, we generate a baseline trajectory by performing evaluations at $s_n = \sqrt{t_n t_{n+1}}$, and a searched trajectory by a greedy grid search on r_n which gives $s_n = t_n^{r_n} t_{n+1}^{1-r_n}$.

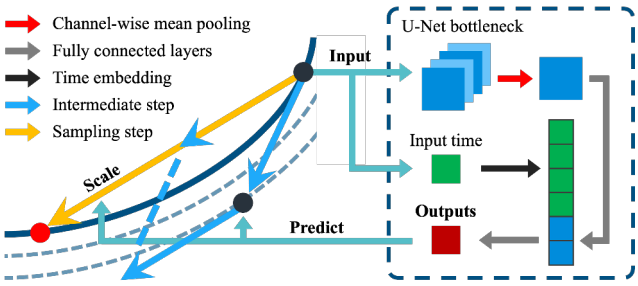


Figure 6. Network Architecture. Given the bottleneck feature extracted by the U-Net model at time t_{n+1}, we perform the channel-wise mean pooling and pass it through two fully connected layers. It is concatenated with the time embedding and goes through one extra fully connected layer and a sigmoid function to output r_n and c_n. The intermediate time step is then given by $s_n = t_n^{r_n} t_{n+1}^{1-r_n}$.

that appropriate choose of intermediate time steps can further improve fast ODE solvers. Therefore, as described in Sec. 3.2, we also train an AMED predictor to predict the intermediate time steps as well as the direction scaling factor. As this process still has the meaning of searching for the direction pointing to the ground truth, we name this method as *AMED-Plugin* and apply it on various fast ODE solvers.

Through Fig. 5, we obtain a direct comparison between DPM-Solver-2 and our proposed AMED-Solver since they share the same baseline trajectory when r is fixed to 0.5. Our AMED-Solver aligns better with the ground truth and the location of searched intermediate time steps is much more stable than that of DPM-Solver-2. We speculate that the gradient direction of DPM-Solver-2 restricted by the fixed r (see Tab. 1) is suboptimal. Instead, the learned coefficients provide AMED-Solver more flexibility to determine a better gradient direction.

3.4. Training and Sampling

As samples from different sampling trajectories approach the asymmetric data manifold, their current locations should contribute to the corresponding trajectory curvatures [6]. To recognize the sample location without extra computation overhead, we extract the bottleneck feature of the pre-trained U-Net model every time after its evaluation. We then take the current and next time step t_{n+1} and t_n along with the bottleneck feature $\mathbf{h}_{t_{n+1}}$ as the inputs to the AMED predictor g_ϕ to predict the intermediate time step s_n and the scaling factor c_n. Formally, we have

$$\{s_n, c_n\} = g_\phi(\mathbf{h}_{t_{n+1}}, t_{n+1}, t_n). \tag{11}$$

The network architecture is shown in Fig. 6.

As for sampling from time t_{n+1} to t_n, we first perform one U-Net evaluation at t_{n+1} and extract the bottleneck feature $\mathbf{h}_{n+1}$ to predict s_n and c_n. For AMED-Solver, we obtain $\mathbf{x}_{s_n}$ by an Euler step from t_{n+1} to s_n and then use Eq. (9) to obtain $\mathbf{x}_{t_n}$. When applying AMED-Plugin on other ODE solvers, we step from t_{n+1} to s_n and s_n to t_n following the original solver's sampling procedure and c_n is used to scale the direction in the latter step. The total NFE is thus $2(N-1)$. We denote such a sampling step from t_{n+1} to t_n by

$$\mathbf{x}_{t_n} = \Phi(\mathbf{x}_{t_{n+1}}, t_{n+1}, t_n, \Lambda_n), \tag{12}$$

where Λ_n is the set of intermediate time steps $s_n \in (t_n, t_{n+1})$ and scaling factors c_n introduced in this step.

The training of g_ϕ is based on knowledge distillation, where the student and teacher sampling trajectories evaluated at Γ are required, and they are denoted as $\{\mathbf{x}_{t_n}\}_{n=1}^N$ and $\{\mathbf{y}_{t_n}\}_{n=1}^N$, respectively. We then denote the sampling process that generates student and teacher trajectories by Φ_s with $\Lambda_n^s = \{s_n, c_n\}$ and Φ_t with Λ_n^t, respectively. Since teacher trajectories require more NFE to give reliable reference, we set the intermediate time steps to be an interpolation of M steps between t_n and t_{n+1} following the original time schedule. Taking the polynomial schedule as example, we set $\Lambda_n^t = \{s_n^1 \cdots, s_n^M, c_n^1 = 1 \cdots, c_n^M = 1\}$, where

$$s_n^i = (t_n^{1/\rho} + \frac{i}{M+1}(t_{n+1}^{1/\rho} - t_n^{1/\rho}))^\rho. \tag{13}$$

We train g_ϕ using a distance metric $d(\cdot,\cdot)$ between samples on both trajectories with $\{s_n, c_n\}$ predicted by g_ϕ:

$$\mathcal{L}_{t_n}(\phi) = d(\Phi_s(\mathbf{x}_{t_{n+1}}, t_{n+1}, t_n, \{s_n, c_n\}), \mathbf{y}_{t_n}) \tag{14}$$

In one training loop, we first generate a batch of noise images at t_N and the teacher trajectories. We then calculate the loss and update g_ϕ progressively from t_{N-1} to t_1. Hence, $N-1$ backpropagations are applied in one training loop. Algorithms for training and sampling is provided in Algorithm 1 and Algorithm 2.

Algorithm 1 Training of g_ϕ

Input: Model parameter ϕ, time schedule $\{t_n\}_{n=1}^N$, ODE solver Φ_s and Φ_t.
repeat
  Sample $\mathbf{x}_{t_N} = \mathbf{y}_{t_N} \sim \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{0}, t_N^2\mathbf{I})$
  Generate a teacher trajectory $\{\mathbf{y}_{t_n}\}_{n=1}^N$ by Φ_t
  for $n = N-1$ **to** 1 **do**
    $\mathbf{x}_{t_n} \leftarrow \Phi_s(\mathbf{x}_{t_{n+1}}, t_{n+1}, t_n, g_\phi(\mathbf{h}_{t_{n+1}}, t_{n+1}, t_n))$
    # $\mathbf{h}_{t_{n+1}}$ is extracted after U-Net evaluation at t_{n+1}.
    $\mathcal{L}_{t_n}(\phi) = d(\mathbf{x}_{t_n}, \mathbf{y}_{t_n})$
    Update the model parameter ϕ
  end for
until convergence

Algorithm 2 AMED Sampling

Input: Trained AMED predictor g_ϕ, time schedule $\{t_n\}_{n=1}^N$, ODE solver Φ.
Sample $\mathbf{x}_{t_N} \sim \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{0}, t_N^2\mathbf{I})$
for $n = N-1$ **to** 1 **do**
  $\mathbf{x}_{t_n} \leftarrow \Phi(\mathbf{x}_{t_{n+1}}, t_{n+1}, t_n, g_\phi(\mathbf{h}_{t_{n+1}}, t_{n+1}, t_n))$
  # $\mathbf{h}_{t_{n+1}}$ is extracted after U-Net evaluation at t_{n+1}.
end for
Output: Generated sample $\mathbf{x}_{t_1}$

Similar to the previous discovery that the sampling trajectory is nearly straight when t is large [6], we notice that the gradient term $\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_\theta(\mathbf{x}_{t_N}, t_N)$ at time t_N shares almost the same direction as $\mathbf{x}_{t_N}$. We thus simply use $\mathbf{x}_{t_N}$ as the direction in the first sampling step to save one NFE, which is important when the NFE budget is limited. This trick is called analytical first step (AFS) [10]. We find that the application of AFS yields little degradation or even increase of sample quality for datasets with small resolutions.

Inspired by the concurrent work [49], when applying our AMED-Plugin on DDIM [43], iPNDM [51] and DPM-Solver++ [26] on datasets with small resolution (32×32 and 64×64), we optionally train additional time scaling factors $\{a_n\}_{n=1}^{N-1}$ through g_ϕ to expand the solution space. Given a_n, we use $\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_\theta(\mathbf{x}_{s_n}, a_n s_n)$ instead of $\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_\theta(\mathbf{x}_{s_n}, s_n)$ when stepping to t_n, which improves results in some cases.

3.5. Comparing with Distillation-based Methods

Though being a solver-based method, our proposed AMED-Solver shares a similar principal with distillation-based methods. The main difference is that distillation-based methods finally build a mapping from noise to data distribution by fine-tuning the pre-trained model or training a new prediction model from scratch [6, 27, 39, 46], while our AMED-Solver still follows the nature of solving an ODE, building a probability flow from noise to image. Distillation-based methods have shown impressive results of performing high-quality generation by only one NFE [46]. However, these methods require huge efforts on training. One should carefully design the training details and it takes a large amount of time to train the model (usually several or even tens of GPU days). Moreover, as distillation-based models directly build the mapping like typical generative models, they suffer from the inability of interpolating between two disconnected modes [40].

Additionally, our training goal is to properly predict several parameters in the sampling process instead of directly predicting high-dimensional samples at the next time as those distillation-based methods. Therefore, our architecture is very simple and is easy to train thanks to the geometric property of sampling trajectories. Besides, our AMED-Solver maintains the nature of ODE solver-based methods, and does not suffer from obvious internal imperfection for downstream tasks.

4. Experiments

4.1. Settings

Datasets. We employ AMED-Solver and AMED-Plugin on a wide range of datasets with image resolutions ranging from 32 to 512, including CIFAR10 32×32 [21], FFHQ 64×64 [17], ImageNet 64×64 [37], LSUN Bedroom 256×256 [50]. We also give quantitative and qualitative results on stable-diffusion [34] with resolution of 512.

Models. The pre-trained models are pixel-space models from [18] and [46] and latent-space model from [34].

Solvers. We reimplement several representative fast ODE solvers including DDIM [43], DPM-Solver-2 [25], multistep DPM-Solver++ [26], UniPC [52] and improved PNDM (iPNDM) [23, 51]. It is worth mentioning that we find iPNDM achieves very impressive results and outperforms other ODE solvers in many cases.

Time schedule. We mainly use the polynomial time schedule with $\rho = 7$, which is the default setting in [18], except for DPM-Solver++ and UniPC where we use logSNR schedule recommended in original papers [26, 52] for better results. Besides, for AMED-Solver on CIFAR10 32×32 [21], FFHQ 64×64 [17] and ImageNet 64×64 [37], we use uniform time schedule which is widely used in papers with a DDPM backbone [15].

Training. The total parameter of the AMED predictor g_ϕ is merely 9k. We train g_ϕ for 10k images, which takes 2-8 minutes on CIFAR10 and 1-3 hours on LSUN Bedroom using a single NVIDIA A100 GPU. L2 norm is used as the distance metric in Eq. (14) for all experiments. We use DPM-Solver-2 [25] or EDM [18] with doubled NFE ($M = 1$) to generate teacher trajectories for AMED-Solver, while using the same solver that generates student trajectories for AMED-Plugin, with $M = 1$ for DPM-Solver-2 and $M = 2$ else. Detailed discussion is provided in Appendix C.2.

Method	NFE			
	3	5	7	9
Multi-step solvers				
DPM-Solver++(3M) [26]	110.0	24.97	6.74	3.42
UniPC [52]	109.6	23.98	5.83	3.21
iPNDM [23, 51]	47.98	13.59	5.08	3.17
Single-step solvers				
DDIM [43]	93.36	49.66	27.93	18.43
EDM [18]	306.2	97.67	37.28	15.76
DPM-Solver-2 [25]	155.7	57.30	10.20	4.98
AMED-Solver (ours)	18.49	7.59	4.36	3.67
AMED-Plugin (ours)	**10.81**†	**6.61**†	**3.65**†	**2.63**†

(a) Unconditional generation on CIFAR10 32×32. We show the results of AMED-Plugin applied on iPNDM.

Method	NFE			
	3	5	7	9
Multi-step solvers				
DPM-Solver++(3M) [26]	91.52	25.49	10.14	6.48
UniPC [52]	91.38	24.36	9.57	6.34
iPNDM [23, 51]	58.53	18.99	9.17	5.91
Single-step solvers				
DDIM [43]	82.96	43.81	27.46	19.27
EDM [18]	249.4	89.63	37.65	16.76
DPM-Solver-2 [25]	140.2	42.41	12.03	6.64
AMED-Solver (ours)	38.10	**10.74**	**6.66**	**5.44**
AMED-Plugin (ours)	**28.06**	13.83	7.81	5.60

(b) Conditional generation on ImageNet 64×64. We show the results of AMED-Plugin applied on iPNDM.

Method	NFE			
	3	5	7	9
Multi-step solvers				
DPM-Solver++(3M) [26]	86.45	22.51	8.44	4.77
UniPC [52]	86.43	21.40	7.44	4.47
iPNDM [23, 51]	45.98	17.17	7.79	4.58
Single-step solvers				
DDIM [43]	78.21	43.93	28.86	21.01
DPM-Solver-2 [25]	266.0	87.10	22.59	9.26
AMED-Solver (ours)	47.31	14.80	8.82	6.31
AMED-Plugin (ours)	**26.87**	**12.49**	**6.64**	**4.24**†

(c) Unconditional generation on FFHQ 64×64. We show the results of AMED-Plugin applied on iPNDM.

Method	NFE			
	3	5	7	9
Multi-step solvers				
DPM-Solver++(3M) [26]	111.9	23.15	8.87	6.45
UniPC [52]	112.3	23.34	8.73	6.61
iPNDM [23, 51]	80.99	26.65	13.80	8.38
Single-step solvers				
DDIM [43]	86.13	34.34	19.50	13.26
DPM-Solver-2 [25]	210.6	80.60	23.25	9.61
AMED-Solver (ours)	**58.21**	**13.20**	**7.10**	**5.65**
AMED-Plugin (ours)	101.5	25.68	8.63	7.82

(d) Unconditional generation on LSUN Bedroom 256×256. We show the results of AMED-Plugin applied on DPM-Solver-2.

Table 2. Results of image generation. Our proposed AMED-Solver and AMED-Plugin achieve state-of-the-art results among solver-based methods in around 5 NFE. †: additional time scaling factors $\{a_n\}_{n=1}^{N-1}$ are trained.

Sampling. Our AMED-Solver and AMED-Plugin naturally create solvers with even NFE. Once AFS is used, the total NFE becomes odd. With the goal of designing fast solvers with the small NFE, we mainly test our method on NFE $\in \{3, 5, 7, 9\}$ where AFS is applied. More results on NFE $\in \{4, 6, 8, 10\}$ without AFS is provided in Appendix C.4.

Evaluation. We measure the sample quality via Fréchet Inception Distance (FID) [14] with 50k images. For Stable-Diffusion, we follow [33] and evaluate the FID value by 30k images generated by 30k fixed prompts sampled from the MS-COCO [22] validation set.

4.2. Image Generation

In this section, we show the results of image generation. For datasets with small resolution such as CIFAR10 32×32, FFHQ 64×64 and ImageNet 64×64, we report the results of AMED-Plugin on iPNDM solver for its leading results. For large-resolution datasets like LSUN Bedroom, we report the results of AMED-Plugin on DPM-Solver-2 since the use of AFS causes inferior results for multi-step solvers in this case (see Appendix C.4 for a detailed discussion). We implement DPM-Solver++ and UniPC with order of 3, iPNDM with order of 4. To report results of DPM-Solver-2 and EDM with odd NFE, we apply AFS in their first steps.

Method	NFE (1 step = 2 NFE)			
	8	12	16	20
DPM-Solver++(2M) [26]	21.33	15.99	14.84	14.58
AMED-Plugin (**ours**)	**18.92**	**14.84**	**13.96**	**13.24**

Table 3. FID results on Stable-Diffusion [34]. The AMED-Plugin is applied on DPM-Solver++(2M).

The results are shown in Tab. 2. Our AMED-Solver outperforms other single-step methods and can even beat multi-step methods in many cases. For the AMED-Plugin, we find it showing large boost when applied on various solvers especially for DPM-Solver-2 as shown in Tab. 2d. Notably, the AMED-Plugin on iPNDM improves the FID by 6.98, 4.68 and 5.16 on CIFAR10 32×32, ImageNet 64×64 and FFHQ 64×64 in 5 NFE. Our methods achieve state-of-the-art results in solver-based methods in around 5 NFE.

As for Stable-Diffusion [34], we use the v1.4 checkpoint with default guidance scale 7.5. Samples are generated by DPM-Solver++(2M) as recommended in the official imple-

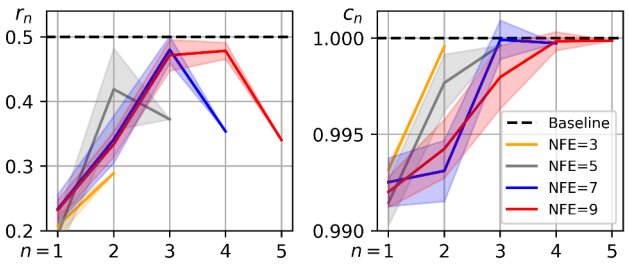


Figure 7. The learned coefficients r_n and c_n vary in different steps and the mean values are consistently lower than the default setting.

Teacher Solver	NFE			
	3	5	7	9
AMED-Solver				
DPM-Solver++(3M) [26]	35.68	12.34	11.28	9.65
iPNDM [23, 51]	32.38	12.42	10.09	8.54
DPM-Solver-2 [25]	**18.49**	11.60	11.64	9.23
EDM [18]	28.99	**7.59**	**4.36**	**3.67**
AMED-Plugin on iPNDM				
DPM-Solver++(3M) [26]	16.00	7.57	4.28	2.85
iPNDM [23, 51]	**10.81**	**6.61**	**3.65**	**2.63**
DPM-Solver-2 [25]	12.07	8.19	4.52	2.66
EDM [18]	29.62	10.58	9.36	4.44

Table 4. Comparison of teacher solvers on CIFAR10.

mentation. The quantitative results are shown in Tab. 3.

In Fig. 7, we show the learned parameters of g_ϕ for AMED-Solver, where r_n and c_n are predicted by g_ϕ and $s_n = t_n^{r_n} t_{n+1}^{1-r_n}$. The dashed line denotes the default setting of DPM-Solver-2. We provide more quantitative as well as qualitative results in Appendix C.

4.3. Ablation Study

Teacher solvers. In Tab. 4, we test AMED-Solver and AMED-Plugin on iPNDM with different teacher solvers for the training of g_ϕ on CIFAR10. It turns out that the best results are achieved when teacher solver resembles the student solver in the sampling process.

Time schedule. We observe that different fast ODE solvers have different preference on time schedules. This preference even depends on the used dataset. In Tab. 5, we provide results for DPM-Solver++(3M) [26] on CIFAR10 with different time schedules and find that this solver prefers logSNR schedule where the interval between the first and second time step is larger than other tested schedules. As a comparison, our AMED-Plugin applied on these cases largely and consistently improves the results, irrespective of the specific time schedule.

5. Conclusion

In this paper, we introduce a single-step ODE solver called AMED-Solver to minimize the discretization error for fast diffusion sampling. Our key observation is that each sampling trajectory generated by existing ODE solvers approximately lies in a two-dimensional subspace, and thus the mean value theorem guarantees the learning of an approximate mean direction. The AMED-Solver effectively mitigates the problem of rapid sample quality degradation, which is commonly encountered in single-step methods, and shows promising results on datasets with large resolution. We also generalize the idea of AMED-Solver to AMED-Plugin, a plugin that can be applied on any fast ODE solvers to further improve the sample quality. We validate our methods through extensive experiments, and our methods achieve state-of-the-art results in extremely small NFE (around 5). We hope our attempt could inspire future works to further release the potential of fast solvers for diffusion models.

Time schedule	NFE			
	3	5	7	9
DPM-Solver++(3M)				
Uniform	76.80	26.90	16.80	13.44
Polynomial	70.04	31.66	11.30	6.45
logSNR	110.0	24.97	6.74	3.42
AMED-Plugin on DPM-Solver++(3M)				
Uniform	33.61	13.24	8.89	8.24
Polynomial	32.47	19.59	9.60	4.39
logSNR	**25.95**	**7.68**	**4.51**	**3.03**

Table 5. FID results under different time schedules on CIFAR10. The DPM-Solver++(3M) shows preference on the uniform logSNR schedule given larger NFE. Our AMED-Plugin consistently improves the results.

Limitation and Future Work. Fast ODE solvers for diffusion models are highly sensitive to time schedules especially when the NFE budget is limited (See Tab. 5). Through experiments, we observe that any fixed time schedule fails to perform well in all situations. In fact, our AMED-Plugin can be treated as adjusting half of the time schedule to partly alleviates but not avoids this issue. We believe that a better designation of time schedule requires further knowledge to the geometric shape of the sampling trajectory [6]. We leave this to the future work.

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Fast ODE-based Sampling for Diffusion Models in Around 5 Steps

Supplementary Material

A. Related Works

Ever since the birth of diffusion models [15, 44], their generation speed has become a major drawback compared to other generative models [12, 19]. To address this issue, efforts have been taken to accelerate the sampling of diffusion models, which fall into two main streams.

One is designing faster solvers. In early works [30, 43], the authors speed up the generation from 1000 to less than 50 NFE by reducing the number of time steps with systematic or quadratic sampling. Analytic-DPM [3], provides an analytic form of optimal variance in sampling process and improves the results. More recently, with the knowledge of interpreting the diffusion process as a PF-ODE [45], there is a class of ODE solvers based on numerical methods that accelerate the sampling process to around 10 NFE. The authors in EDM [18] achieve several improvements on training and sampling of diffusion models and propose to use Heun's second method. PDNM [23] uses linear multi-step method to solve the PF-ODE with Runge-Kutta algorithms for the warming start. The authors in [51] recommend to use lower order linear multi-step method for warming start and propose iPNDM. Given the semi-linear structure of the PF-ODE, DPM-Solver [25] and DEIS [51] are proposed by approximate the integral involved in the analytic solution of PF-ODE with Taylor expansion and polynomial extrapolation respectively. DPM-Solver is further extend to both single-step and multi-step methods in DPM-Solver++ [26]. UniPC [52] gives a unified predictor-corrector solver and improved results compared to DPM-Solver++.

Besides training-free fast solvers above, there are also solvers requiring additional training. [48] proposes a series of reparameterization for a generalized family of DDPM with a KID [5] loss. More related to our method, in GENIE [10], the authors apply the second truncated Taylor method [32] to the PF-ODE and distill a new model to predict the higher-order gradient term. Different from this, in AMED-Solver, we train a network that only predict the intermediate time steps, instead of a high-dimensional output.

Another mainstream is training-based distillation methods, which attempt to build a direct mapping from noise distribution to implicit data distribution. This idea is first introduced in [27] as an offline method where one needs to preconstruct a dataset generated by the original model. Rectified flow [24] also introduces an offline distillation based on optimal transport. For online distillation methods, one can progressively distill a diffusion model from more than 1k steps to 1 step [4, 39], or utilize the consistency property of PF-ODE trajectory to tune the denoising output [8, 13, 46].

B. Experimental Details

Datasets. We employ AMED-Solver and AMED-Plugin on a wide range of datasets and settings. We report results on settings including unconditional generation in both pixel and latent space, conditional generation with or without guidance. Datasets are chosen with image resolutions ranging from 32 to 512, including CIFAR10 32×32 [21], FFHQ 64×64 [17], ImageNet 64×64 [37] and LSUN Bedroom 256×256 [50]. We give quantitative and qualitative results generated by stable-diffusion [34] with resolution of 512. To further evaluate the effectiveness of our methods, in Appendix C, we also include more results on ImageNet 256×256 [37] with classifier guidance and latent-space LSUN Bedroom 256×256 [50].

Models. The pre-trained models we use throughout our experiments are pixel-space models from [18], [46] as well as [9], and latent-space models from [34]. Our code architecture is mainly based on the implementation in [18].

Fast ODE solvers. To give fair comparison, we reimplement several representative fast ODE solvers including DDIM [43], DPM-Solver-2 [25], multi-step DPM-Solver++ [26], UniPC [52] and improved PNDM (iPNDM) [23, 51]. Through the implementation, we obtain better or on par FID results compared with original papers. It is worth mentioning that during the implementation, we find iPNDM achieves very impressive results and outperforms other ODE solvers in many cases.

Time schedule. We notice that different ODE solvers have different preference on time schedule. We mainly use the polynomial time schedule with $\rho = 7$, which is the default setting in [18], except for DPM-Solver++ and UniPC where we use logSNR time schedule recommended in original papers [26, 52] for better results. As illustrated in Sec. 3.4, the logSNR schedule is the limit case of polynomial schedule as ρ approaches $+\infty$. Besides, for AMED-Solver on CIFAR10 32×32 [21], FFHQ 64×64 [17] and ImageNet 64×64 [37], we use uniform time schedule which is widely used in papers with a DDPM [15] backbone. This uniform time schedule is transferred from its original range $[0.001, 1]$ to $[t_1, t_N]$ in our setting following the EDM [18] implementation. For experiments on ImageNet 256×256 with classifier guidance and latent-space LSUN Bedroom, the uniform time schedule gives best results. The reason may lie in their different training process.

Training. Since there are merely 9k parameters in the AMED predictor g_ϕ, its training does not cause much computational cost. The training process spends its main time on generating student and teacher trajectories. We train g_ϕ

for 10k images, which takes 2-8 minutes on CIFAR10 and 1-3 hours on LSUN Bedroom using a single NVIDIA A100 GPU. For the distance metric in Eq. (14), we use L2 norm in all experiments. For the generation of teacher trajectories for AMED-Solver, we use DPM-Solver-2 [25] or EDM [18] with doubled NFE ($M = 1$). For AMED-Plugin, we use the same solver that generates student trajectories with $M = 1$ for DPM-Solver-2 and $M = 2$ else.

Sampling. Due to designation, our AMED-Solver or AMED-Plugin naturally create solvers with even NFE. Therefore once AFS is used, the total NFE become odd. With the goal of designing fast ODE solvers in extremely small NFE, we mainly test our method on NFE $\in \{3, 5, 7, 9\}$ where AFS is applied. There are also results on NFE $\in \{4, 6, 8, 10\}$ without using AFS.

Evaluation. We measure the sample quality via Frechet Inception Distance (FID) [14], which is a well-known quantitative evaluation metric for image quality that aligns well with human perception. For all the experiments involved, we calculate FID with 50k samples using the implementation in [18]. For Stable-Diffusion, we follow [33] and evaluate the FID value by 30k samples generated by 30k fixed prompts sampled from the MS-COCO [22] validation set.

C. Additional Results

C.1. Fast Degradation of Single-step Solvers

In pilot experiments, we find that the fast degradation of single-step solvers can be alleviated by appropriate choose of the intermediate time steps. As shown in Tab. 6, the performance of DPM-Solver-2 is very sensitive to the choice of its hyperparameter r. We apply AMED-Plugin to learn the appropriate r and find that it achieves similar results with the best searched r while adding little training overhead and negligible sampling overhead.

r	NFE			
	4	6	8	10
0.1	28.75	17.61	11.00	5.30
0.2	24.44	21.94	8.23	4.17
0.3	37.31	30.27	6.82	**3.89**
0.4	75.06	43.32	7.34	4.20
0.5 (default)	146.0	60.00	10.30	5.01
0.6	241.2	79.27	15.62	6.38
AMED-Plugin	**24.44**	**17.10**	**6.60**	4.73

Table 6. Performance of DPM-Solver-2 on CIFAR10 is sensitive to the choice of r. Applying AMED-Plugin on DPM-Solver-2 efficiently help to learn the appropriate r.

C.2. Ablation Study on Intermediate Steps

As illustrated in Sec. 3.4, for the teacher sampling trajectory, M intermediate time steps are injected in every sampling step. We use a smooth interpolation, meaning that the teacher time schedule given by the original schedule Γ combined with injected time steps, is equivalent to the time schedule obtained by simply setting the total number of time steps to $(M + 1)(N - 1) + 1$ in Eq. (10) under the same ρ. In this way, we can easily extract samples on teacher trajectories at Γ to get reference samples $\{\mathbf{y}_{t_n}\}_{n=1}^{N}$.

Here we take unconditional generation on CIFAR10 using iPNDM with AMED-Plugin as an example and provide an ablation study on the choose of M. The student and teacher solvers are set to be the same. The results are shown in Tab. 7.

M	NFE			
	3	5	7	9
1	25.98	7.53	4.01	2.77
2	**10.81**	**6.61**	**3.65**	2.63
3	11.20	7.00	4.15	2.63
4	10.92	7.40	3.69	**2.61**
5	12.87	7.70	3.65	2.75

Table 7. The sensitivity of M on CIFAR10 with AMED-Plugin on iPNDM. Additional time scaling factors are trained.

C.3. Ablation Study on Bottleneck Feature Input and Time Scaling Factor

As the U-Net bottleneck input to g_ϕ varies for different samples, the learned parameters are sample-wise, meaning that different trajectories have different time schedules. Since sampling trajectories from different starting points share similar geometric shapes, the effectiveness of inputting bottleneck might be limited. We also notice that during training, the standard deviation of learned parameters in one batch is small. Therefore, we should test if the U-Net bottleneck feature input is necessary. In Tab. 8 we replace U-Net bottleneck feature with zero matrix (w/o bottleneck) and get shared parameters across all sampling trajectories. The results show the effectiveness of the bottleneck feature input. Besides, the use of time scaling factors provides improved results. When applying our AMED-Plugin on DDIM [43], iPNDM [51] and DPM-Solver++ [26] on datasets with small resolution (32×32 and 64×64), we optionally train this time scaling factors through g_ϕ to expand the solution space.

Method	NFE			
	3	5	7	9
iPNDM [23, 51]	47.98	13.59	5.08	3.17
AMED-Plugin (w/ bottleneck)	15.87	7.29	3.92	2.82
AMED-Plugin (w/o bottleneck) †	11.12	7.31	3.80	2.64
AMED-Plugin (w/ bottleneck) †	**10.81**	**6.61**	**3.65**	**2.63**

Table 8. Ablation study of the bottleneck feature input on CIFAR10 with AMED-Plugin on iPNDM. †: additional time scaling factors are trained.

C.4. Ablation Study on AFS

The trick of analytical first step (AFS) is first introduced in [10] to reduce one NFE, where the authors replace the U-Net output in the first sampling step with the direction of x_T. In Tab. 10 and Tab. 11, we provide extended results of Tab. 2a and Tab. 2b as well as the ablations between AFS and our proposed AMED-Plugin. We find that the use of AFS provides consistent improvement on datasets with resolutions of 32 and 64. The results show that in most cases they can be considered as two independent components that can together boost the performance of various ODE solvers. However, for datasets with large resolutions, applying AFS usually causes a large degradation (see Tab. 9).

Method	AFS	NFE			
		3	5	7	9
DPM-Solver++(3M) [26]	✗	111.9	23.15	8.87	6.45
	✓	127.5	25.04	10.51	7.32
UniPC [52]	✗	112.3	23.34	8.73	6.61
	✓	127.3	25.78	10.50	7.20
iPNDM [23, 51]	✗	80.99	26.65	13.80	8.38
	✓	95.61	34.61	21.96	10.06
DPM-Solver-2 [25]	✗	210.6	80.60	23.25	9.61
	✓	241.8	88.79	22.59	9.07
AMED-Solver (**ours**)	✓	**58.51**	**13.20**	**7.10**	**5.65**

Table 9. Ablation study of AFS on pixel-space LSUN Bedroom 256×256.

C.5. More Quantitative Results

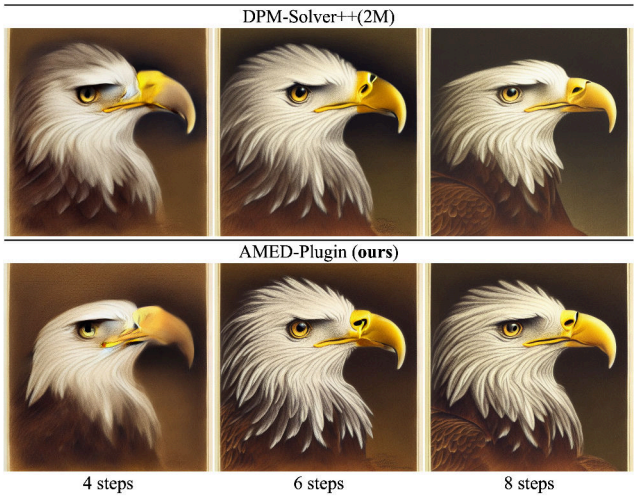
In this section, we provide additional quantitative results on more datasets including latent-space LSUN Bedroom 256×256 [34, 50] and ImageNet 256×256 [37] with classifier guidance [9]. The results are shown in Tab. 12 and Tab. 13.

C.6. More Qualitative Results

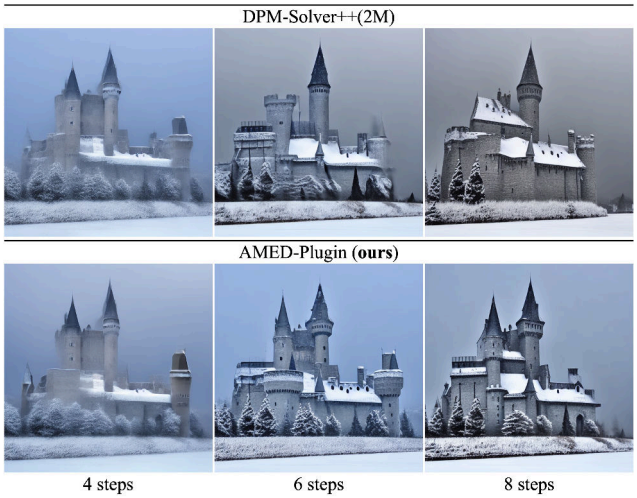
We give more qualitative results generated by stable-diffusion-v1 [34] with a default classifier-free guidance scale 7.5 in Fig. 8. Results on various datasets with NFE of 3 and 5 are provided from Fig. 10 to Fig. 15.

D. Theoretical Analysis

In Sec. 3.1, we experimentally showed that the sampling trajectory of diffusion models generated by an ODE solver almost lies in a two-dimensional subspace embedded in the ambient space. This is the core condition for the mean value theorem to approximately hold in the vector-valued function case. However, the sampling trajectory would not necessarily lie in a plane. In this section, we analyze to what extent will this affects our AMED-Solver, where we set the two-dimensional subspace to be the place spanned by the first two principal components.



(a) Text prompt: "*A portrait of an eagle*".



(b) Text prompt: "*Under a gray sky, a castle in ice and snow*".

(c) Text prompt: "*A motorcycle racer is bending*".

Figure 8. Synthesized images by Stable-Diffusion v1.4 [34] with default classifier-free guidance scale 7.5.

Method	AFS	**AMED**	NFE							
			3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
Multi-step solvers										
UniPC [52]	✗	✗	109.6	45.20	23.98	11.14	5.83	3.99	3.21	2.89
	✓	✗	54.36	20.55	9.01	5.75	4.11	3.26	2.93	2.65
DPM-Solver++(3M) [26]†	✗	✗	110.0	46.52	24.97	11.99	6.74	4.54	3.42	3.00
	✓	✗	55.74	22.40	9.94	5.97	4.29	3.37	2.99	2.71
	✗	✓	-	21.62	-	6.82	-	4.41	-	2.76
	✓	✓	25.95	-	7.68	-	4.51	-	3.03	-
iPNDM [23, 51]†	✗	✗	47.98	24.82	13.59	7.05	5.08	3.69	3.17	2.77
	✓	✗	24.54	13.92	7.76	**5.07**	4.04	**3.22**	2.83	2.56
	✗	✓	-	**10.43**	-	6.67	-	3.34	-	**2.48**
	✓	✓	**10.81**	-	**6.61**	-	**3.65**	-	**2.63**	-
Single-step solvers										
DDIM [43]†	✗	✗	93.36	66.76	49.66	35.62	27.93	22.32	18.43	15.69
	✓	✗	67.26	49.96	35.78	28.00	22.37	18.48	15.69	13.47
	✗	✓	-	37.72	-	25.15	-	17.03	-	11.33
	✓	✓	38.23	-	24.44	-	15.72	-	10.93	-
DPM-Solver-2 [25]	✗	✗	-	146.0	-	60.00	-	10.30	-	5.01
	✓	✗	155.7	-	57.28	-	10.20	-	4.98	-
	✗	✓	-	24.44	-	17.10	-	6.60	-	4.73
	✓	✓	38.48	-	28.14	-	7.46	-	4.73	-
AMED-Solver (**ours**)	✗	✓	-	**17.18**	-	**7.04**	-	**5.56**	-	**4.14**
	✓	✓	**18.49**	-	**7.59**	-	**4.36**	-	**3.67**	-

Table 10. Unconditional generation on CIFAR10 32×32. †: additional time scaling factors $\{a_n\}_{n=1}^{N-1}$ are trained.

Method	AFS	**AMED**	NFE							
			3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
Multi-step solvers										
UniPC [52]	✗	✗	91.38	55.63	24.36	14.30	9.57	7.52	6.34	5.53
	✓	✗	64.54	29.59	16.17	11.03	8.51	6.98	6.04	5.26
DPM-Solver++(3M) [26]†	✗	✗	91.52	56.34	25.49	15.06	10.14	7.84	6.48	5.67
	✓	✗	65.20	30.56	16.87	11.38	8.68	7.12	6.25	5.58
	✗	✓	-	53.28	-	13.68	-	7.98	-	5.57
	✓	✓	76.51	-	15.21	-	8.36	-	6.04	-
iPNDM [23, 51]	✗	✗	58.53	33.79	18.99	12.92	9.17	7.20	5.91	5.11
	✓	✗	34.81	**21.32**	15.53	**10.27**	8.64	**6.60**	5.64	**4.97**
	✗	✓	-	23.55	-	12.05	-	7.03	-	5.01
	✓	✓	**28.06**	-	**13.83**	-	**7.81**	-	**5.60**	-
Single-step solvers										
DDIM [43]†	✗	✗	82.96	58.43	43.81	34.03	27.46	22.59	19.27	16.72
	✓	✗	62.42	46.06	35.48	28.50	23.31	19.82	17.14	15.02
	✗	✓	-	40.85	-	32.46	-	20.72	-	15.52
	✓	✓	46.10	-	33.54	-	21.94	-	15.56	-
DPM-Solver-2 [25]	✗	✗	-	129.8	-	44.83	-	12.42	-	6.84
	✓	✗	140.2	-	42.41	-	12.03	-	6.64	-
	✗	✓	-	40.99	-	31.19	-	11.24	-	6.94
	✓	✓	70.64	-	29.96	-	11.54	-	6.91	-
AMED-Solver (**ours**)	✗	✓	-	**32.69**	-	**10.63**	-	**7.71**	-	**6.06**
	✓	✓	**38.10**	-	**10.74**	-	**6.66**	-	**5.44**	-

Table 11. Conditional generation on ImageNet 64×64. †: additional time scaling factors $\{a_n\}_{n=1}^{N-1}$ are trained.

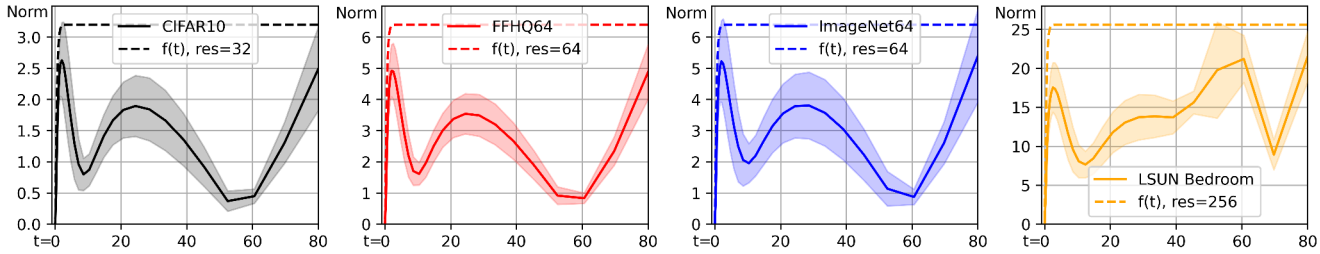


Figure 9. Following the experiment in Sec. 3.1, we calculate $\|\mathbf{x}_t - \tilde{\mathbf{x}}_t\|_2$ and find that we can bound it by a proper setting of Eq. (16).

Method	NFE			
	4	6	8	10
DPM-Solver++(3M) [26]	48.55	10.01	4.61	3.62
AMED-Plugin (**ours**)	**15.67**	**8.92**	**4.19**	**3.52**

Table 12. Unconditional generation on latent-space LSUN Bedroom. AMED-Plugin is applied on DPM-Solver++.

Method	NFE			
	4	6	8	10
Guidance scale = 8.0				
DPM-Solver++(3M) [26]	60.01	25.51	**11.98**	**7.95**
AMED-Plugin (**ours**)	**39.84**	**21.79**	13.94	9.05
Guidance scale = 4.0				
DPM-Solver++(3M) [26]	27.15	10.25	7.10	6.15
AMED-Plugin (**ours**)	**24.19**	**8.86**	**6.54**	**5.72**
Guidance scale = 2.0				
DPM-Solver++(3M) [26]	**23.06**	10.17	7.04	5.92
AMED-Plugin (**ours**)	28.81	**9.56**	**6.42**	**5.46**

Table 13. Conditional generation on ImageNet256 with classifier guidance. AMED-Plugin is applied on DPM-Solver++.

Notations. Denote d as the dimension of the ambient space. Let $\{\mathbf{x}_\tau\}_{\tau=\epsilon}^T$ to be the solution of the PF-ODE Eq. (6). Let $\{\tilde{\mathbf{x}}_\tau\}_{\tau=\epsilon}^T$ to be the trajectory obtained by projecting $\{\mathbf{x}_\tau\}_{\tau=\epsilon}^T$ to the two-dimensional subspace spanned by its first two principal components. Given $\epsilon \le s < m < t \le T$ and a constant c, one step of the AMED-Solver is given by

$$\mathbf{x}_s^A = \mathbf{x}_t + c(s-t)\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_\theta(\mathbf{x}_m, m). \tag{15}$$

Define the scaled logistic function to be

$$f(\tau) = a\left(\frac{1}{1+e^{-b\tau}} - \frac{1}{2}\right), \tau \in \mathbb{R}; a, b \in \mathbb{R}^+. \tag{16}$$

Finally, define a SDE

$$\mathrm{d}\mathbf{z}_\tau = g(\tau)\mathrm{d}\mathbf{w}_\tau, \tau \in [s, t] \tag{17}$$

with initial value $\mathbf{0}$ at t where $g(\tau)$ is a real-valued function and $\mathbf{w}_\tau \in \mathbb{R}^d$ is the standard Wiener process.

We start by the following assumptions:

Assumption 1. *Assume that there exists $a, b > 0$ s.t. $\|\mathbf{x}_\tau - \tilde{\mathbf{x}}_\tau\|_2 \le f(\tau), \tau \in [\epsilon, T]$.*

For the choice of a and b, in Fig. 9, we calculate $\|\mathbf{x}_\tau - \tilde{\mathbf{x}}_\tau\|_2$ following the experiment settings in Sec. 3.1. We experimentally find that $\|\mathbf{x}_\tau - \tilde{\mathbf{x}}_\tau\|_2$ can be roughly upper bounded by setting $a = \sqrt{3d}/15$ and $b = 3$.

Assumption 2. *Assume that there exists an integrable function $\boldsymbol{\omega} : \mathbb{R}^{d+1} \to \mathbb{R}^d$ that generate $\{\tilde{\mathbf{x}}_\tau\}_{\tau=\epsilon}^T$ by*

$$\tilde{\mathbf{x}}_s = \tilde{\mathbf{x}}_t + \int_t^s \boldsymbol{\epsilon}_\theta(\mathbf{x}_\tau, \tau) + \boldsymbol{\omega}(\mathbf{x}_\tau, \tau)\mathrm{d}\tau. \tag{18}$$

with initial value $\tilde{\mathbf{x}}_T$. In this way, we can decompose the integral in Eq. (7) into two components that parallel and perpendicular to the plane where $\{\tilde{\mathbf{x}}_\tau\}_{\tau=\epsilon}^T$ lies, i.e.,

$$\begin{aligned}\int_t^s \boldsymbol{\epsilon}_\theta(\mathbf{x}_\tau, \tau)\mathrm{d}\tau = &\int_t^s \boldsymbol{\epsilon}_\theta(\mathbf{x}_\tau, \tau)\boldsymbol{\omega}(\mathbf{x}_\tau, \tau)\mathrm{d}\tau \\ &- \int_t^s \boldsymbol{\omega}(\mathbf{x}_\tau, \tau)\mathrm{d}\tau.\end{aligned} \tag{19}$$

Assumption 3. *Decompose $\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_\theta(\mathbf{x}_m, m)$ in Eq. (15) into two components as in Assumption 2 that parallel and perpendicular to the plane where $\{\tilde{\mathbf{x}}_\tau\}_{\tau=\epsilon}^T$ lies:*

$$\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_\theta(\mathbf{x}_m, m) = \boldsymbol{\epsilon}_\theta^{\parallel}(\mathbf{x}_m, m) + \boldsymbol{\epsilon}_\theta^{\perp}(\mathbf{x}_m, m). \tag{20}$$

Assume that the parallel component is optimally learned and for the perpendicular component, we have

$$\left\|c(s-t)\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_\theta^{\perp}(\mathbf{x}_m, m)\right\|_2 \le \left\|\int_t^s \boldsymbol{\omega}(\mathbf{x}_\tau, \tau)\mathrm{d}\tau\right\|_2. \tag{21}$$

Assumption 4. *There exists such a $g(\tau)$ s.t. with high probability that*

$$\left\|\int_t^s \boldsymbol{\omega}(\tilde{\mathbf{x}}_\tau, \tau)\mathrm{d}\tau\right\|_2 \le \|\mathbf{z}_s\|_2. \tag{22}$$

Lemma 1. *Under assumption 1 and 4, let $g(\tau) = f(\tau)/\sqrt{d}$, then $\mathbf{z}_s$ concentrates at a thin shell with radius*

$$r(s,t) = \frac{a}{\sqrt{b}}\sqrt{\frac{1}{1+e^x}\Big|_{bs}^{bt} + \frac{b}{4}(t-s)}. \tag{23}$$

Proof. Since the SDE Eq. (17) has zero drift coefficient, its perturbation kernel $p(\mathbf{z}_s|\mathbf{z}_t = \mathbf{0})$ is a Gaussian with zero mean [41]. The covariance $\mathbf{P}(s,t)$ is given by

$$\mathbf{P}(s,t) = \int_s^t g^2(\tau)\mathrm{d}\tau\mathbf{I} \tag{24}$$

$$= \frac{a^2}{d}\int_s^t \left(\frac{1}{1+e^{-b\tau}} - \frac{1}{2}\right)^2 \mathrm{d}\tau\mathbf{I} \tag{25}$$

$$= \underbrace{\frac{a^2}{bd}\left(\frac{1}{1+e^x}\Big|_{bs}^{bt} + \frac{b}{4}(t-s)\right)}_{\sigma^2(s,t)}\mathbf{I}. \tag{26}$$

By the well-known concentration of measure [47], there exists a constant $c > 0$ s.t. for any $h \geq 0$, we have

$$\mathbb{P}\left(\left|\|\mathbf{z}_s\|_2 - |\sigma(s,t)|\sqrt{d}\right| \geq h\right) \leq 2e^{-ch^2} \tag{27}$$

which complete the proof. □

Proposition 1. *Given $\epsilon \leq s < t \leq T$, under the assumptions and Lemma 1 above, with high probability we have*

$$\left\|\mathbf{x}_s - \mathbf{x}_s^A\right\|_2 \leq f(s) + f(t) + r(s,t). \tag{28}$$

Proof. Under assumptions and Lemma 1 above, we have

$$\left\|\mathbf{x}_s - \mathbf{x}_s^A\right\|_2 \tag{29}$$

$$\leq \|\mathbf{x}_s - \tilde{\mathbf{x}}_s\|_2 + \left\|\tilde{\mathbf{x}}_s - \mathbf{x}_s^A\right\|_2 \tag{30}$$

$$\leq f(s) + \Big\|\mathbf{x}_t - \tilde{\mathbf{x}}_t + c(s-t)\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_\theta(\mathbf{x}_m, m) \tag{31}$$

$$- \int_t^s \boldsymbol{\epsilon}_\theta(\mathbf{x}_\tau,\tau) + \boldsymbol{\omega}(\mathbf{x}_\tau,\tau)\mathrm{d}\tau\Big\|_2 \tag{32}$$

$$\leq f(s) + f(t) + \Big\|c(s-t)\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_\theta^\perp(\mathbf{x}_m, m) \tag{33}$$

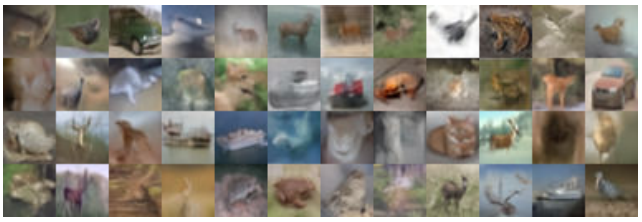
$$+ c(s-t)\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_\theta^\parallel(\mathbf{x}_m, m) - \int_t^s (\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_\theta + \boldsymbol{\omega})(\mathbf{x}_\tau,\tau)\mathrm{d}\tau\Big\|_2 \tag{34}$$

$$\leq f(s) + f(t) + \left\|c(s-t)\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_\theta^\perp(\mathbf{x}_m, m)\right\|_2 \tag{35}$$

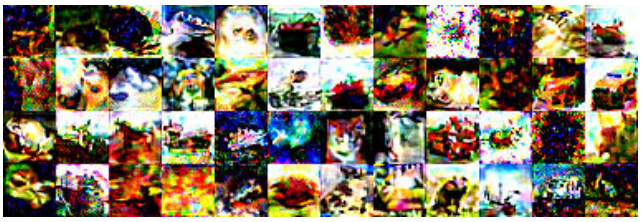
$$\leq f(s) + f(t) + \left\|\int_t^s \boldsymbol{\omega}(\mathbf{x}_\tau,\tau)\mathrm{d}\tau\right\|_2 \tag{36}$$

$$\leq f(s) + f(t) + r(s,t) \tag{37}$$

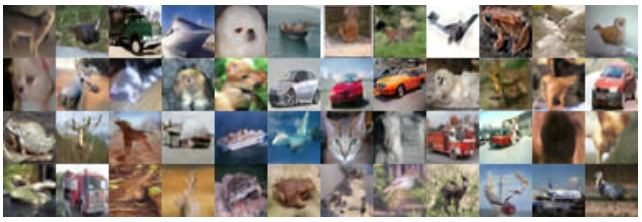
with high probability. □



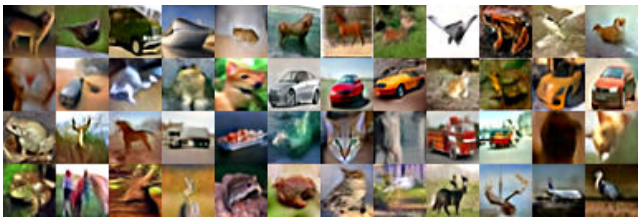
(a) Baseline iPNDM solver. FID = 47.98.



(b) Baseline DPM-Solver-2. FID = 155.7.



(c) AMED-Plugin applied on iPNDM solver. FID = 10.81.



(d) AMED-Solver. FID = 18.49.

Figure 10. Uncurated samples on CIFAR10 32×32 with 3 NFE.

(a) Baseline iPNDM solver. FID = 58.53.

(b) Baseline DPM-Solver-2. FID = 140.2.

(c) AMED-Plugin applied on iPNDM solver. FID = 28.06.

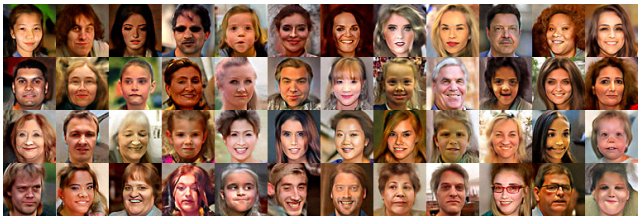
(d) AMED-Solver. FID = 38.10.

Figure 11. Uncurated samples on Imagenet 64×64 with 3 NFE.

(a) Baseline iPNDM solver. FID = 45.98.

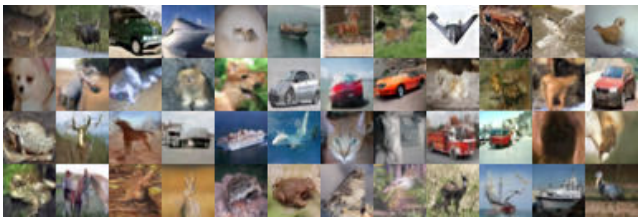
(b) Baseline DPM-Solver-2. FID = 266.0.

(c) AMED-Plugin applied on iPNDM solver. FID = 26.87.

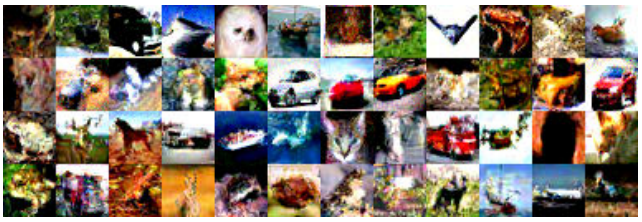


(d) AMED-Solver. FID = 47.31.

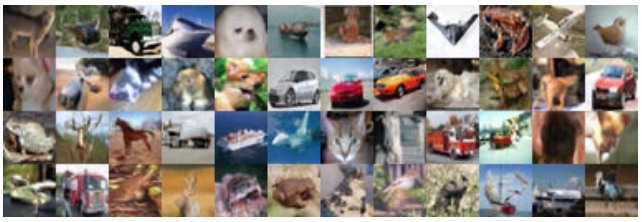
Figure 12. Uncurated samples on FFHQ 64×64 with 3 NFE.



(a) Baseline iPNDM solver. FID = 13.59.



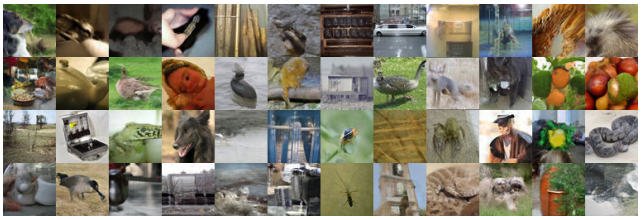
(b) Baseline DPM-Solver-2. FID = 57.30.



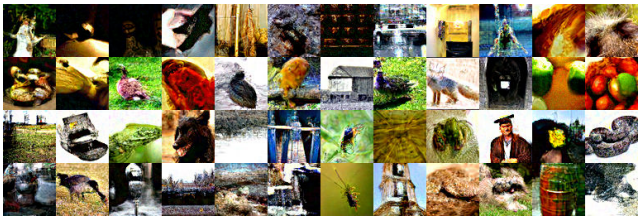
(c) AMED-Plugin applied on iPNDM solver. FID = 6.61.

(d) AMED-Solver. FID = 7.59.

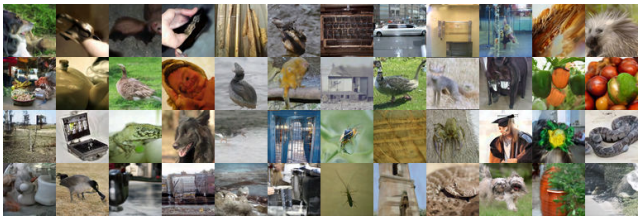
Figure 13. Uncurated samples on CIFAR10 32×32 with 5 NFE.



(a) Baseline iPNDM solver. FID = 18.99.



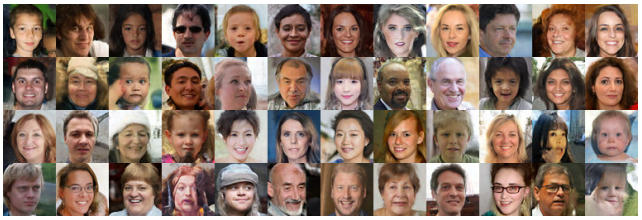
(b) Baseline DPM-Solver-2. FID = 42.41.



(c) AMED-Plugin applied on iPNDM solver. FID = 13.83.

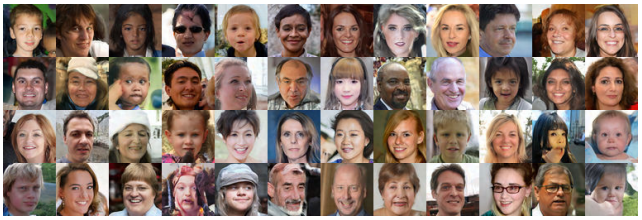
(d) AMED-Solver. FID = 10.74.

Figure 14. Uncurated samples on Imagenet 64×64 with 5 NFE.

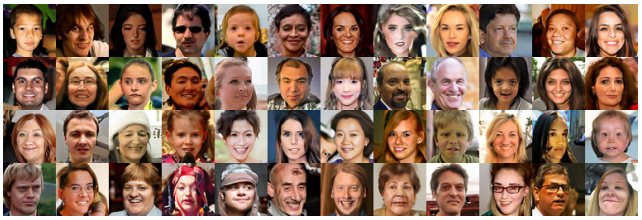


(a) Baseline iPNDM solver. FID = 17.17.

(b) Baseline DPM-Solver-2. FID = 87.10.



(c) AMED-Plugin applied on iPNDM solver. FID = 12.49.



(d) AMED-Solver. FID = 14.80.

Figure 15. Uncurated samples on FFHQ 64×64 with 5 NFE.